

Central and South America

Les Pitons

Location Soufrière Bay, St. Lucia, Lesser Antilles

Translated as “the Peaks,” Les Pitons are two adjacent forest-clad volcanic lava domes that rise from the Atlantic Ocean and tower over St. Lucia. Linked by Piton Mitan Ridge, steep-sided Gros Piton (2,526 ft high/770 m) and Petit Piton (at 2,438 ft/743 m) are cloaked in tropical and (at higher elevations) subtropical moist forest. Sulfurous fumaroles, hot springs, and deposits of ash, pumice, and lava flows are all indications of the volcanic origins of the peaks, which are the remains of a collapsed stratovolcano. The region was declared a World Heritage Site in 2004.

The Paracas Peninsula

Location Pacific coast of Peru

Sometimes referred to as the Galápagos Islands of Peru, the Paracas Peninsula is part of Peru’s only marine reserve. This arid peninsula extends into the Pacific Ocean toward the cold, nutrient-rich Humboldt Current, which is extremely rich in fish and other oceanic life forms and attracts huge numbers of seabirds, including Humboldt penguins, as well as whales, dolphins, and sea turtles. A massive prehistoric design (or geoglyph), the Paracas Candelabra, has been carved into the north side of the peninsula; pottery found nearby dates from 200 BCE and could be of the same age.

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